Intergenerational Mobility in the Value of a Job

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Abstract

Intergenerational mobility is usually measured in income, yet workers value job amenities as well as pay. We measure intergenerational mobility in the value of a job, which reflects both amenities and pay. Using a revealed preference approach, we infer the value of each job from voluntary moves in the labor market, including job-to-job transitions and quits into nonemployment. We embed this approach in a job ladder model in which workers differ in preferences and job opportunities. Weekly benefit records let us distinguish quits, which reveal preferences, from layoffs, which do not. Using Danish administrative data, we document that there is 37% less intergenerational persistence in job value than in earnings: the rank-rank slope is 0.11 in job value and 0.18 in earnings. A key reason behind this gap is that the children of high-earning parents tend to hold jobs that pay more but have worse amenities. Evidence from surveys suggests that these jobs are more demanding: they involve greater competition, longer hours, and greater time pressure.